

Editorial: Past, Present, and Future

“EachMovie: archaeology of a first latent recommender system”

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Introduction

My ACM RecSys 2026 paper “EachMovie: archaeology of a first latent recommender system” [2] is part of that conference’s decennial “Past, Present & Future” track. My conference presentation includes some additional material not in the paper. This Editorial briefly lists a couple of the new points introduced there.

Warning: The conference presentation includes this new material in a deliberately personal Editorial context. That same personal perspective continues here. This is all just my opinion. This is a too-brief Editorial.

1 Past

As noted in the paper, EachMovie cultivated a high degree of user engagement and trust. Its users *wanted* to use EachMovie, and to help it model their tastes and their souls.¹

EachMovie’s users were invited to write in, and many did [3]. One particular respondent wrote:

I’ve been using it for two months, and it’s eerily good at predicting what I’ll like ... One of my favorite games with EachMovie is to enter a bogus rating, just to see how it affects the predictions; when I revert to my true opinion, EachMovie recalculates all its predictions instantly. ... A better predictor, and more fun to use. [5]

The manner in which this user twiddled EachMovie’s knobs is like a textbook example of *human agency* [1] in an online system [7]. This human user (whom I recognized as a former colleague) could act intentionally; she could control her environment; and she could shape her experiences. In short, EachMovie *let her drive*.

The EachMovie team did not plan for this most excellent outcome. It was an emergent property, but a very welcome one. It was completely accidental, but I would argue that this is exactly the type of outcome we should try to replicate in our modern recommender systems.

1.1 Letting users drive

Letting users drive is the important contribution of this Editorial. But read on anyway.

2 Present

That was then (1996) and this is now (2026). My historical paper’s Conclusions section was called “Back to the future,” and arguably followed the rather anodyne conclusion of that movie [8]. This new editorial content in the conference presentation more closely follows the unplanned sequel “Back to the Future Part II” [9].

¹The reference to “souls” here is deliberate. Movies, done well, reflect the human soul, and they shape the human soul. This is true of all good art. I posit that latent recommender systems for humans have a similar *potential* to reflect the human soul (via their users’ votes as carried into its internal models) and to shape the human soul (via their recommendations to their users). I believe this is true regardless of our current systems’ massive shortcomings.

Our own current world can then be viewed as a divergent timeline, as in that second movie. Biff Tannen² is running the casino, and he’s dialing the figurative doomsrollamine³ all the way up to 11. Ours is arguably the wrong timeline. We’re all doomed. Or maybe not. Let’s hope not.

3 Future

Yes, there are two paths you can go by,
but in the long run
There’s still time to change the road you’re on.

Stairway to Heaven, Robert Plant, 1971

What to do? I do not know, but it “really makes me wonder” [6]. Perhaps the first step is to build systems to help users drive again.

Acknowledgments

My wife is the fabulous Laurie Shaw-DeTreville. Many thanks to Laurie, and to Christine Seawell (UCI English) as well, for so quickly reviewing drafts of these appendices, and for so patiently listening to me tell them all about my work over so many decades.

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²Biff Tannen is the movie’s bad guy, who gains excessive control over the dystopian “Hell Valley” by unscrupulous means.

³This very recent neologism is from Andrew Marlton [4]. It combines “doomsroll” with “dopamine,” the chemical that floods the brain following rewards, helping to create addiction via neuroplasticity. That is not a good combination.